

PARIKSHA365 — STUDY NOTES

English — for SSC & RRB

SSC/RRB focus: vocabulary (synonyms, antonyms, OWS, idioms, spelling), error spotting, fill-blanks, sentence improvement

SSC

RRB

v 2026-04

The promise. Read this book end-to-end (with the usual two re-reads + active recall on the embedded prompts) and you will be able to attempt every quiz question in the Pariksha365 pool for this subject with a strong fundamental grasp.

How to use this book

English in competitive exams is **not** literature. It is **pattern recognition on a fixed set of grammar rules and a fixed vocabulary of trap-words**. Memorise the rules, drill the traps, you score.

Same type-first discipline:

- **Opener** — why this topic matters, minimum-rule list you must internalise.
 - **Types** — the error patterns / question patterns examiners recycle.
 - **For each type** — trigger phrase → rule → example → common trap → self-check.
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PART 1 — PARTS OF SPEECH & SENTENCE STRUCTURE

1.0 Opener

English questions test one of 8 parts of speech (noun, pronoun, verb, adjective, adverb, preposition, conjunction, interjection). 95 % of error-spotting targets **verbs (tense/agreement), prepositions, pronouns, conjunctions**.

Types

1. **Noun count** — singular vs plural collective nouns (team, jury, audience → context).
 2. **Pronoun case** — I vs me, he vs him, who vs whom.
 3. **Pronoun agreement** — "Each of the students **has** ..." (singular "each").
 4. **Adjective vs adverb** — "He runs **quickly**" (not "quick").
 5. **Degree of comparison** — "one of the tallest buildings" (superlative + plural).
 6. **Preposition fixed pairs** (below).
 7. **Conjunction pairs** (below).
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PART 2 — TENSES (the Big Engine)

2.0 Opener

12 tenses = 4 forms × 3 times.

	Simple	Continuous	Perfect	Perfect Continuous
Past	went	was going	had gone	had been going
Present	go / goes	is/are going	has/have gone	has/have been going
Future	will go	will be going	will have gone	will have been going

Types

1. **Time-phrase cues** — each cue locks a specific tense:

- **Yesterday, last year, ago, in 2010** → **simple past** (definite past time) *I went to Delhi last year.*
- **Since + point in time (since Monday, since 2010)** → **present perfect** or **present perfect continuous** *I have lived here since 2015.*
- **For + duration (for 2 hours, for 5 years)** → **present perfect (continuous)** *She has been working here for three years.*
- **While + ing / when + ... was/were ing** → **past continuous** *While I was reading, the phone rang.*
- **By + future time (by next year)** → **future perfect** *By 2030, India will have become the third largest economy.*
- **Just, already, yet, ever, never, recently, lately** → **present perfect** *I have just finished my homework.*
- **Always, often, usually, rarely, every day** → **simple present** *He always wakes up at 6 AM.*

Type 0 (general truth / habit) — both halves use present simple - Form: **If + present simple, present simple** - Example: *If you heat ice, it melts.*

Type 1 (likely future / real condition) — talks about a real possibility - Form: **If + present simple, will + base verb (V1)** - Example: *If it rains tomorrow, we will cancel the picnic.*

Type 2 (unlikely / hypothetical present) — talks about something improbable now - Form: **If + past simple, would + base verb (V1)** - Example: *If I won the lottery, I would buy a*

house. - Note: with "be", use **were** for all subjects (subjunctive) — *If I were you, I would apologise.*

Type 3 (impossible past / contrary to fact) — talks about something that did NOT happen - Form: **If + had + past participle (V3), would have + past participle (V3)** - Example: *If I had studied harder, I would have passed the exam.*

Mixed conditional (past condition → present result) — combines Type 3 if-clause with Type 2 result - Form: **If + had + V3, would + V1** - Example: *If I had taken that job in 2020, I would be a manager today.* 3. **Subjunctive** — "I wish / if only I **were** ..." (not "was"). 4.

Reported speech — back-shift of tense after "said that". 5. **"As soon as / no sooner ... than / hardly ... when / scarcely ... when"** — formal inversion patterns. Each on its own line:

- **No sooner had + S + V3 ... than + S + V (past simple)** *No sooner had I sat down than the bell rang.*
 - **Hardly had + S + V3 ... when + S + V (past simple)** *Hardly had we left when it started raining.*
 - **Scarcely had + S + V3 ... when + S + V (past simple)** *Scarcely had he spoken when she interrupted him.*
 - **As soon as + S + V (past) , S + V (past)** — no inversion needed *As soon as the train arrived, passengers rushed in.* 6. **Future perfect** — "by next year I **will have** finished" (completion before a future time).
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PART 3 — SUBJECT-VERB AGREEMENT

3.0 Opener

Most common error class. Memorise these rules cold.

Types

1. **Either / or, neither / nor** — verb agrees with the noun **closer** to it. "Neither the teacher nor the students **are** wrong."
 2. **With/along with/as well as/besides/including** — verb agrees with the **first** subject. "The principal, along with teachers, **is** attending."
 3. **Collective nouns** — family, team, jury, government → singular when acting as unit; plural when members act individually.
 4. **Uncountables** (news, furniture, information, advice, luggage, machinery, poetry, scenery, bread) → always singular.
 5. **Always plural** — trousers, scissors, spectacles, goods, thanks, wages, premises.
 6. **"Each / every / either / neither / none"** + singular verb.
 7. **A pair of / a number of / a great deal of** — "a number of" → plural verb; "the number of" → singular verb.
 8. **Mathematical subjects** — maths, physics, economics, statistics, politics — singular.
 9. **Distance / money / time as single units** — "Ten miles **is** a long walk."
 10. **"There is / there are"** — agrees with the real subject after it.
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PART 4 — ARTICLES (a / an / the)

4.0 Opener

- **a / an** used for indefinite countable singular. Choice depends on SOUND, not letter: "an hour" (silent h), "a university" (sounds /ju:/).
- **the** used for (i) specific mentioned/known thing, (ii) superlatives, (iii) ordinals, (iv) unique things (the sun, the moon), (v) names of rivers/oceans/seas/mountain ranges/gulfs/deserts (the Ganges, the Himalayas), (vi) names of newspapers/ships (the Hindu, the Titanic), (vii) adjectives used as plural nouns (the poor, the rich).

Types

1. **Missing article before a known/unique noun.**
 2. **Extra article before abstract noun / plural uncountable** ("Honesty is the best policy" — no article before honesty).
 3. **"A" vs "An" by sound** — "an MBA", "a one-eyed man".
 4. **Countries** — normally no "the" (India, USA-exception: The USA because it's plural of States; The Netherlands).
 5. **Superlatives + ordinals** always take "the".
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PART 5 — PREPOSITIONS (memorise the pairs)

5.0 Opener

Prepositions in English are largely idiomatic — there is no rule; you must memorise the fixed verb-preposition / adjective-preposition pairs. Below are the most-tested ones.

High-frequency fixed pairs

- **accuse of, charge with, agree to (a proposal) / agree with (a person) / agree on (a matter).**
- **consist of, comprise [no of], amount to.**
- **differ from (things) / differ with (person) / differ on (topic).**
- **afraid of, aware of, capable of, desirous of, fond of, proud of, sick of, tired of, weary of.**
- **acquainted with, angry with (person) / angry at (thing).**
- **good at, bad at, clever at, expert at.**
- **die of (disease), die for (cause), die by (hand of), die from (exhaustion).**
- **look at (see), look after (take care of), look for (search), look into (investigate), look up (find in ref), look down on (despise), look forward to (V-ing).**
- **depend on, insist on, rely on, concentrate on, impose on.**
- **congratulate on, compliment on, decide on.**
- **prevent from, suffer from, refrain from, prohibit from, abstain from.**
- **married to** (not "married with"), **engaged to.**
- **superior to, inferior to, junior to, senior to, prior to, prefer X to Y** — all take "to", NOT "than".

Types

1. **Wrong preposition after a fixed verb / adjective** — error spotting. Memorise pairs.
 2. **Missing preposition** — "discuss **about**" is wrong; "discuss" takes no preposition.
 3. **Double preposition** — "enter **into**" is wrong for physical entry; correct only for agreement ("enter into a contract").
 4. **"Prefer X to Y"** — NEVER "prefer X than Y".
 5. **Time-place pairs** — in (month / year / morning), on (day / date), at (clock time).
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PART 6 — CONJUNCTIONS

Types

1. **Coordinating** (FANBOYS — for, and, nor, but, or, yet, so) — connect equals.
 2. **Subordinating** — introduce dependent clauses (because, although, since, unless, until, while).
 3. **Correlative pairs** — either / or, neither / nor, not only / but also, both / and, whether / or, hardly / when, no sooner / than.
 4. **Parallelism** — correlatives must connect same parts of speech. "She is **not only** intelligent **but also** hardworking." (both adjectives.)
 5. **"Lest" + should/subjunctive** — "Run fast lest you **should** miss the bus."
 6. **"Unless"** = "if not" — never add "not" after unless. Wrong: "unless you don't study".
 7. **"Scarcely/hardly ... when"; "no sooner ... than"**.
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PART 7 — VOICE (ACTIVE ↔ PASSIVE)

7.0 Opener

Passive = be + V3. The **object** of active becomes subject of passive; active subject becomes "by + agent" (or dropped).

Types

1. **Simple conversion** — "Ram writes a letter" → "A letter is written by Ram."
 2. **Continuous tense** — "is writing" → "is being written".
 3. **Perfect tense** — "has written" → "has been written".
 4. **Modals** — "can write" → "can be written"; "must write" → "must be written".
 5. **Imperatives** — "Open the door" → "Let the door be opened."
 6. **"Let"-construction** — "Let him do it" → "Let it be done by him."
 7. **Interrogatives** — "Is Ram writing?" → "Is a letter being written by Ram?"
 8. **Double object** — "She gave him a gift" → "A gift was given to him" or "He was given a gift."
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PART 8 — DIRECT ↔ INDIRECT SPEECH (NARRATION)

8.0 Opener

Rules: - Reporting verb past → back-shift tenses in reported clause. -
"Today/yesterday/tomorrow" → "that day / previous day / next day". - "This/these/here/now" →
"that/those/there/then". - Pronouns shift to match speaker perspective.

Types

1. **Statements** — "He said, 'I am ill'" → "He said that he was ill."
 2. **Questions** — reporting verb becomes "asked / enquired"; that-clause uses statement order.
 3. **Yes/No questions** — use "if" or "whether".
 4. **Imperatives** — reporting verb becomes "ordered / requested / advised / told"; reported clause uses infinitive: "Don't make noise" → "He asked them not to make noise."
 5. **Exclamations** — "How beautiful!" → "He exclaimed that it was very beautiful."
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PART 9 — ERROR SPOTTING

9.0 Opener

The highest-frequency MCQ format. Sentence split into 4 parts (A, B, C, D); candidate picks the part with the error (or "No error").

Checklist (run in this order — catches 95 % of errors): 1. Subject-verb agreement (Part 3). 2. Tense consistency. 3. Pronoun agreement. 4. Preposition (Part 5). 5. Article (Part 4). 6. Parallelism in conjunctions (Part 6). 7. Redundancy (return back, repeat again, final outcome, true facts, past history). 8. Comparatives: "more better" ✗, "most strongest" ✗. 9. Gerund vs infinitive after specific verbs (enjoy + V-ing, decide + to-V, stop + V-ing vs stop + to-V).

Types (by error class)

1. **S-V agreement errors.**
 2. **Tense errors.**
 3. **Preposition errors.**
 4. **Article errors.**
 5. **Pronoun errors.**
 6. **Redundancy.**
 7. **Comparative / superlative misuse.**
 8. **Conjunction / parallelism errors.**
 9. **Gerund / infinitive misuse.**
 10. **Misplaced modifier.**
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PART 10 — SENTENCE IMPROVEMENT / PHRASE REPLACEMENT

Similar to error spotting, but the candidate is given 4 replacements for an underlined phrase.

Method: identify what's wrong with the underlined part first (don't read options). Then pick the option that fixes the specific error without adding new ones.

PART 11 — CLOZE TEST

11.0 Opener

Passage with 5-10 blanks. Options per blank.

Method: 1. Read the whole passage once for sense — don't look at options. 2. For each blank, predict your own word/phrase from context. 3. Match options to your prediction. 4. Use trigger words: "however" → contrast; "moreover" → addition; "because" → cause.

Types

1. **Pure vocabulary** — synonym-level.
 2. **Grammar + vocab mix** — article or preposition blanks alongside word blanks.
 3. **New-age cloze** — each blank has 4-5 options that differ subtly.
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PART 12 — READING COMPREHENSION (RC)

12.0 Opener

Method (Stepwise): 1. **Skim** — get topic + structure in 30-60 s. Don't memorise; locate. 2. **Read questions next** — know what to hunt. 3. **Scan** the passage for the exact phrase / concept each question needs. 4. **Eliminate extremes** — answers with words like "always / never / entirely / only" are often traps. 5. **Pick the option closest to a paraphrase of what the passage LITERALLY says** — not what you infer further.

Question Types

1. **Main idea / title** — about the whole passage.
 2. **Detail / fact** — a specific sentence supports this.
 3. **Inference** — implied but not stated.
 4. **Tone / attitude** — author's stance (critical / supportive / neutral / ironic).
 5. **Vocabulary in context** — meaning of a word *as used here*.
 6. **Synonym / antonym** drawn from passage.
 7. **Structural** — purpose of paragraph 2.
 8. **"Which of the following is NOT ..."** — watch the negative.
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PART 13 — PARA-JUMBLES (SENTENCE REARRANGEMENT)

13.0 Opener

5-6 sentences are jumbled; candidate must arrange in a logical order.

Method: 1. Find the **opening sentence** — usually introduces a concept, doesn't refer back. 2. Find **linkers** — "however, therefore, this, such, they" → refers to a previous sentence. 3. Find the **ending sentence** — conclusion, consequence. 4. Chain: who → does what → so what → consequence.

Common traps: a pronoun in Sentence B must follow its antecedent in Sentence A.

PART 14 — FILL IN THE BLANKS

Single-blank, double-blank, triple-blank variants. Grammar- or vocab-driven.

- Double-blank: find the pair that works for BOTH blanks. Often the pair is syntactically parallel.
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PART 15 — VOCABULARY (Synonyms, Antonyms, Idioms, One-word Substitutions, Spellings)

15.0 Opener

Why separate discipline: vocab cannot be taught by rules; it must be memorised. But a **high-frequency list** saves 80 % effort.

Preparation plan: 1. **High-frequency root+prefix+suffix** list (300 entries) — e.g., mis-, dis-, -able, -ous, bio-, geo-, -cracy. 2. **500 high-frequency SSC + Banking synonyms/antonyms** drilled across a month. 3. **100 high-frequency idioms** ("to bite the dust", "let the cat out of the bag", "pulling your leg"). 4. **One-word substitutions** — "person who can speak many languages = polyglot", "person who talks to himself = soliloquist". 5. **Commonly misspelt words** — accommodate, occurrence, separate, privilege, embarrassment, millennium.

Types of Questions

1. **Synonym** (choose word closest in meaning).
 2. **Antonym** (choose opposite).
 3. **Idiom meaning**.
 4. **One-word substitution**.
 5. **Spelling** (choose the correctly spelt one).
 6. **Foreign phrases** (status quo, bona fide, vice versa, per se, ad hoc).
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APPENDIX A — Master checklist for error spotting (memorise)

1. S-V agreement.
2. Tense consistency.
3. Pronoun case & agreement.
4. Prepositions (fixed pairs).
5. Articles.
6. Parallel structure.
7. Redundancy.
8. Comparatives.
9. Gerund/infinitive.
10. Modifier placement.

APPENDIX B — 50 most-tested preposition traps

(see Part 5; drill this list till it's reflex.)

APPENDIX C — 100 most-tested idioms (separate assets file)

APPENDIX D — Reading-comprehension traps

1. **"Extreme" options** ("always", "never", "completely").
 2. **Out-of-scope inferences** that go beyond the passage.
 3. **Opposite-tone distractors** (passage supportive, option critical).
 4. **Over-specific numerical traps** in factual questions — check the passage verbatim.
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PART 16 — DEEP-DRILL VOCABULARY ESSENTIALS (high-yield list)

16.1 Top-100 SSC + Banking SYNONYMS to drill (with one-line meaning)

Word	Meaning	Synonym to remember
Abate	reduce	diminish, mitigate
Acrid	bitter (smell/taste)	pungent, harsh
Adamant	unyielding	inflexible, obstinate
Affable	friendly	amiable, cordial
Alleviate	reduce pain	mitigate, ease
Ambiguous	unclear	vague, equivocal
Apathy	lack of interest	indifference
Arduous	very difficult	strenuous, laborious
Astute	sharp-witted	shrewd, perceptive
Audacious	bold (often reckless)	daring, intrepid
Banal	unoriginal	trite, hackneyed
Belligerent	hostile	combative
Benevolent	kind	benign, generous
Brevity	shortness	conciseness, terseness
Candid	frank	forthright, blunt
Capricious	impulsive	fickle, whimsical
Censure	strong criticism	rebuke, condemn
Coalesce	merge	unite, fuse
Convolutd	complex	intricate, twisted
Copious	abundant	plentiful, ample
Credulous	gullible	naive, trusting
Deference	respect	esteem, regard
Deride	mock	ridicule, scoff
Despot	tyrant	autocrat, dictator

Word	Meaning	Synonym to remember
Diligent	hardworking	assiduous, conscientious
Disparage	belittle	denigrate
Eclectic	varied source	diverse, broad
Egregious	shockingly bad	flagrant, atrocious
Elucidate	explain	clarify, illuminate
Emulate	imitate (to equal)	mirror, follow
Ephemeral	short-lived	transient, fleeting
Eradicate	remove totally	eliminate, exterminate
Erudite	scholarly	learned, well-read
Exacerbate	make worse	aggravate, worsen
Exonerate	clear of blame	acquit, absolve
Extol	praise highly	laud, eulogize
Fervent	passionate	ardent, zealous
Flippant	not serious	frivolous, glib
Frugal	thrifty	economical, sparing
Garrulous	talkative	loquacious
Hapless	unfortunate	unlucky
Hegemony	dominance	supremacy
Iconoclast	image-breaker (lit/fig)	rebel, dissenter
Impede	obstruct	hinder, thwart
Impervious	unaffected by	resistant, immune
Inculcate	instil	implant, infuse
Indolent	lazy	slothful, idle
Inevitable	unavoidable	certain
Insidious	tasteless	bland, dull
Intrepid	fearless	brave, bold
Jubilant	very happy	elated, exultant
Laconic	brief in speech	terse, succinct
Lethargic	sluggish	sleepy, torpid
Lucid	clear	coherent, intelligible

Word	Meaning	Synonym to remember
Magnanimous	generous (esp to enemies)	noble, big-hearted
Mendacious	lying	dishonest, untruthful
Meticulous	very careful	thorough, fastidious
Mitigate	reduce severity	alleviate, soften
Munificent	very generous	bountiful, liberal
Myriad	very many	countless
Nefarious	wicked	evil, villainous
Obfuscate	confuse	obscure, muddle
Obstinate	stubborn	adamant, mulish
Opulent	wealthy, lavish	affluent, plush
Ostentatious	showy	flashy, pretentious
Palpable	tangible	obvious, evident
Paragon	a perfect model	epitome, exemplar
Pedantic	overly precise	nit-picking
Perfunctory	done with little care	cursory, superficial
Pernicious	harmful	injurious, destructive
Pithy	brief and forceful	succinct, terse
Placate	calm down	appease, mollify
Plethora	excess	abundance, surfeit
Pragmatic	practical	sensible, realistic
Precarious	unstable	risky, dangerous
Procrastinate	delay	postpone, defer
Profligate	wasteful	extravagant
Proliferate	multiply rapidly	grow, increase
Prudent	careful	cautious, judicious
Quell	suppress	crush, subdue
Quintessential	most typical	classic, archetypal
Recalcitrant	uncooperative	defiant, intractable
Repudiate	reject	renounce, disown
Resilient	bouncing back	tough, hardy

Word	Meaning	Synonym to remember
Sagacious	wise	astute, insightful
Scrupulous	morally careful	principled, ethical
Sedulous	diligent	persistent
Sporadic	occasional	infrequent, intermittent
Stoic	unaffected by emotion	impassive, unflinching
Stringent	strict	rigorous, severe
Sycophant	flatterer	toady, bootlicker
Tantamount	equivalent	equal to
Taciturn	uncommunicative	reserved, silent
Tenacious	persistent	dogged, relentless
Trepidation	fear/anxiety	apprehension
Ubiquitous	present everywhere	omnipresent
Vacillate	waver	hesitate, oscillate
Verbose	wordy	long-winded
Vex	annoy	irritate, frustrate
Vindicate	justify, clear	exonerate
Voluble	speaks a lot, fluently	talkative, articulate
Wary	cautious	guarded, vigilant
Zealous	passionate	enthusiastic, fervent

Drill rule: cover the right side, see the word, recall meaning + 1 synonym in <2 s.

16.2 Top-50 high-frequency ANTONYMS (often paired with the synonyms above)

Word	Antonym
Abundant	scarce
Amateur	professional
Amicable	hostile
Bold	timid

Word	Antonym
Calm	agitated
Concise	verbose
Concrete	abstract
Conspicuous	inconspicuous
Contradict	corroborate
Cordial	aloof
Diligent	indolent
Dispel	gather
Eccentric	conventional
Eloquent	inarticulate
Embellish	mar
Eminent	unknown
Frivolous	serious
Genuine	spurious
Gregarious	introverted
Humble	arrogant
Implicit	explicit
Innocent	guilty
Lethargic	energetic
Lucid	obscure
Lustrous	dull
Modest	flamboyant
Notorious	reputable
Optimist	pessimist
Praise	denounce
Profound	superficial
Prudent	reckless
Radical	conservative
Rare	common
Rebellious	obedient

Word	Antonym
Reluctant	willing
Reveal	conceal
Rigid	flexible
Robust	feeble
Sacred	profane
Stingy	generous
Tedious	exciting
Transient	permanent
Trivial	significant
Turbulent	placid
Vague	precise
Valiant	cowardly
Vehement	mild
Vibrant	dull
Wane	wax
Zenith	nadir

16.3 Top-100 ONE-WORD SUBSTITUTIONS (memorise — 4-6 questions per SSC paper)

People:

- One who eats everything → **Omnivore** (eats only meat → Carnivore; only plants → Herbivore)
- One who eats human flesh → **Cannibal**
- One who can speak many languages → **Polyglot**
- One who knows many subjects → **Polymath**; only one subject → **Specialist**
- One who hates mankind → **Misanthrope** (hates women → Misogynist; hates men → Misandrist; hates marriage → Misogamist)
- One who loves humanity → **Philanthropist** (loves books → Bibliophile; loves wine → Oenophile; loves nature → Naturalist)
- One who studies plants → **Botanist**; animals → Zoologist; birds → Ornithologist; insects → Entomologist; coins → Numismatist; stamps → Philatelist; ancient writing → Palaeographer; fossils → Palaeontologist; earthquakes → Seismologist; weather → Meteorologist; poetry → Poet; star/heavenly bodies → Astronomer/Astrologer
- One who walks in sleep → **Somnambulist**; talks in sleep → Somniloquist

- One who is new to a job → **Novice / Tyro / Neophyte**
- One who copies from others' work → **Plagiarist**; counterfeits → Forger
- One who lives alone → **Recluse / Hermit**
- One who is unable to pay debts → **Insolvent / Bankrupt**
- One who renounces the throne → **Abdicator**
- One who is hard to please → **Fastidious**
- One who is all-powerful → **Omnipotent**; all-knowing → Omniscient; present everywhere → Omnipresent
- One who looks at the bright side → **Optimist**; dark side → Pessimist
- One who studies blood → **Haematologist**; heart → Cardiologist; skin → Dermatologist; bones → Orthopaedist; cancer → Oncologist; eyes → Ophthalmologist; ear-nose-throat → ENT/Otolaryngologist; women → Gynaecologist; children → Paediatrician; mind → Psychologist/Psychiatrist; teeth → Dentist; old age → Gerontologist
- One who works for free → **Volunteer**
- One who is just/impartial → **Neutral**
- One who shows off learning → **Pedant**
- One who is greedy for money → **Avaricious**
- One who has a strong desire for something → **Aspirant**

Things / abstract:

- Government by one → **Autocracy**; few → Oligarchy; many → Democracy; women → Matriarchy / Gynocracy; men → Patriarchy; rich → Plutocracy; the worst → Kakistocracy; experts → Technocracy; clergy → Theocracy; nobility → Aristocracy; the elderly → Gerontocracy
- Killing of king → **Regicide**; father → Patricide; mother → Matricide; brother → Fratricide; sister → Sororicide; child → Infanticide; self → Suicide; race/group → Genocide; humans (general) → Homicide; insects → Pesticide / Insecticide; weeds → Herbicide; bacteria → Germicide; environment → Ecocide
- Fear of height → **Acrophobia**; closed places → Claustrophobia; open places → Agoraphobia; water → Hydrophobia; foreigners → Xenophobia; animals → Zoophobia; spiders → Arachnophobia; darkness → Nyctophobia; death → Thanatophobia; books → Bibliophobia; speaking in public → Glossophobia; needles → Aichmophobia; blood → Hemophobia
- Mania for stealing → **Kleptomania**; setting fire → Pyromania; books → Bibliomania; alcohol → Dipsomania; one idea → Monomania; greatness → Megalomania
- A short trip → **Excursion**; long sea voyage → Voyage; exploring expedition → Expedition
- Public sale → **Auction**
- A speech without preparation → **Extempore / Impromptu**
- Words inscribed on a tomb → **Epitaph**
- Life history written by oneself → **Autobiography**; by another → Biography
- An exact copy → **Replica / Facsimile**
- That which cannot be defeated → **Invincible**; cannot be approached → Inaccessible; cannot be heard → Inaudible; cannot be read → Illegible; cannot be cured → Incurable; cannot be erased → Indelible; cannot be expressed → Inexpressible / Ineffable; cannot be

quenched → Insatiable; cannot be avoided → Inevitable; cannot be believed → Incredible; cannot be seen → Invisible; cannot be moved → Immovable

- Words used in the same situation → **Cliché / Platitude**
- Continuing forever → **Perpetual / Perennial**
- A child whose parents are dead → **Orphan**; whose parents/wife dead → Widow/Widower
- A place where corpses are buried → **Cemetery**; burnt → Crematorium; museum of artifacts → Museum; for orphans → Orphanage; old/sick → Asylum/Sanatorium; for plants → Greenhouse / Conservatory; for fish → Aquarium; for grain storage → Granary; for arms storage → Armoury / Arsenal; for animals → Zoo; for birds → Aviary; for bees → Apiary; for horses → Stable; for cows → Byre; for pigs → Sty; for sheep → Pen / Fold

16.4 Top-100 IDIOMS (high-frequency in SSC, RRB, Banking)

Idiom	Meaning
A bolt from the blue	sudden shock
A cock-and-bull story	unbelievable story
A drop in the ocean	very small amount
A feather in one's cap	proud achievement
A man of straw	weak/insignificant person
A piece of cake	very easy task
A red letter day	memorable day
A wild goose chase	useless pursuit
Above board	honest, transparent
Achilles' heel	a weak point
Add fuel to the fire	worsen a bad situation
All ears	very attentive
All in all	overall
At a stone's throw	very near
At daggers drawn	bitter enmity
At sixes and sevens	confused, in disarray
Back to the drawing board	start again
Beat about the bush	avoid the point
Bell the cat	take a bold first step
Bite the bullet	endure painful inevitability
Bite the dust	be defeated/die

Idiom	Meaning
Black sheep	disreputable family member
Blow one's own trumpet	self-praise
Break the ice	start a conversation
Bring to light	reveal
Burn the midnight oil	study/work late
Burn one's fingers	suffer for meddling
Burning question	hot/important issue
Bury the hatchet	end a quarrel
By and large	mostly
By leaps and bounds	very rapidly
Call it a day	stop working
Call a spade a spade	speak frankly
Carry the day	win
Cat-and-dog life	quarrelsome existence
Catch red-handed	caught in the act
Chip off the old block	resembling parent
Cock and bull story	absurd story
Cold shoulder	deliberate snub
Come to terms	reach agreement / accept
Cross swords	quarrel
Crocodile tears	fake sorrow
Cry over spilt milk	regret what cannot be undone
Cut a sorry figure	poor impression
Cut to the quick	hurt deeply
Dark horse	unexpected winner
Donkey's years	a very long time
Down in the dumps	depressed
Eat humble pie	apologise / admit error
Every Tom, Dick and Harry	any ordinary person
Face the music	bear consequences

Idiom	Meaning
Fair-weather friend	friend only in good times
Fall flat	fail to impress
Feather in one's cap	honour
Fish out of water	uncomfortable in unfamiliar place
Flash in the pan	brief unrepeated success
Foot the bill	pay
For a song	very cheap
French leave	absence without permission
From hand to mouth	living without savings
Get cold feet	lose courage
Give the cold shoulder	ignore
Go to the dogs	deteriorate
Hand in glove	very close (often suspiciously)
Have an axe to grind	personal interest at stake
Hit the nail on the head	be exactly right
Hue and cry	loud public outcry
In black and white	in writing
In a nutshell	briefly
In the long run	eventually
In the same boat	same situation
Iron hand	strict control
Jump the gun	act prematurely
Keep the wolf from the door	avoid hunger/poverty
Kick the bucket	die
Lend a hand	help
Let the cat out of the bag	reveal a secret
Lion's share	major portion
Look daggers at	glare angrily
Lose face	be humiliated
Make a clean breast	confess fully

Idiom	Meaning
Make ends meet	manage on small income
Make hay while the sun shines	use opportunity
Move heaven and earth	use every means
Nip in the bud	stop at the start
Null and void	invalid
Off and on	occasionally
Once in a blue moon	very rarely
Out of the blue	suddenly
Pass the buck	shift blame
Pay through the nose	pay too much
Pull a long face	look sad
Pull one's leg	tease
Put one's foot down	act firmly
Read between the lines	infer hidden meaning
Rest on one's laurels	stop trying after success
Ride the high horse	act arrogantly
Rule of thumb	rough guideline
See eye to eye	agree
Show the white feather	reveal cowardice
Sit on the fence	remain neutral
Smell a rat	suspect foul play
Spill the beans	reveal a secret
Steal a march	gain an advantage stealthily
Take to one's heels	run away
Take with a pinch of salt	not believe entirely
Tall claim	exaggerated assertion
Throw cold water on	discourage
Through thick and thin	in good times and bad
To and fro	back and forth
Tooth and nail	with all might

Idiom	Meaning
Turn a deaf ear	ignore
Turn over a new leaf	reform
Under one's nose	right in front
Under the weather	unwell
Up in arms	strongly opposed
Wash one's hands of	refuse responsibility
Wear one's heart on one's sleeve	show emotion openly
Wet blanket	spoil-sport
White elephant	costly useless possession
Win hands down	win easily
With a high hand	tyrannically

16.5 50 commonly-misspelt words (drill in pairs)

accommodate, achievement, acquaintance, address, beautiful, beggar, beginning, believe, businessman, calendar, ceiling, cemetery, colleague, committee, conscience, conscientious, convenient, deceive, definitely, despair, embarrass, enthusiastic, exaggerate, fascinate, foreign, fulfil, gauge, government, grammar, grateful, harass, hindrance, humorous, hypocrisy, immediately, independence, indispensable, inoculate, intelligence, knowledge, leisure, liaison, lieutenant, maintenance, manoeuvre, millennium, miscellaneous, mischievous, necessary, occasion, occurrence, omitted, parallel, perseverance, possess, privilege, professional, pronunciation, queue, recommend, referred, restaurant, rhythm, schedule, separate, sergeant, sieve, sincerely, sovereign, succeed, surveillance, tomorrow, twelfth, until, vacuum, weird

16.6 30 high-yield FOREIGN PHRASES (Latin / French)

Phrase	Meaning
ad hoc	for a specific purpose
ad infinitum	endlessly
alma mater	one's old school
bona fide	genuine, in good faith
carpe diem	seize the day
carte blanche	full freedom
caveat emptor	let the buyer beware
chargé d'affaires	acting ambassador

Phrase	Meaning
coup d'état	sudden seizure of power
de facto	in practice
de jure	by law
déjà vu	already seen
en masse	as a group
ex officio	by virtue of office
ex parte	from one party only
fait accompli	accomplished fact
in absentia	while absent
in toto	entirely
ipso facto	by that very fact
laissez-faire	non-interference
modus operandi	method of working
nolens volens	willingly or not
per capita	per person
per se	by itself
persona non grata	unwelcome person
post mortem	after death (analysis)
prima facie	at first sight
pro rata	proportional
quid pro quo	something for something
sine die	indefinitely
sine qua non	indispensable condition
status quo	existing state
sub judice	under trial
tête-à-tête	private chat
vice versa	the reverse
vis-à-vis	with regard to

PART 17 — BANKS-FOCUS DEEP DRILL

(PO/Clerk/RRB Bank, IBPS+SBI+RBI)

17.1 What's different in Banking English

Banking exams (IBPS PO/Clerk, SBI PO/Clerk, RBI Asst./Grade-B, IBPS RRB) have:

- **Long Reading-Comprehension passages (350-500 words)** with 7-10 questions on inference, tone, vocab-in-context.
- **Cloze tests** with 8-10 blanks, often "phrase-replacement cloze" (each blank replaced with a phrase).
- **Para-jumbles** (5-6 sentences); sometimes "para-completion" — you pick a sentence to complete the paragraph.
- **Sentence-rearrangement / starters** — variations like odd-one-out sentence.
- **Spotting error / sentence improvement** (heavy on phrasal verbs + idiomatic preposition).
- **NEW pattern (2024-26)**: paragraph-based fill-in-the-blanks; column matching of phrases.

Negligible weight on: synonyms, antonyms, OWS, idiom-meaning (those are SSC heavy). So drill RC + cloze + sentence rearrangement deeper.

17.2 RC method — Banks deep-drill

1. **Type the passage in 10 s** — economy/finance / society / science / story-philosophy. Tone changes by type.
2. **Skim** for paragraph-1 (problem/topic), last paragraph (verdict/conclusion) — 30 s.
3. **Read questions next** — 4 categories: detail, inference, tone, vocab.
4. **For each question**, point to the LINE that supports it. If you cannot point, eliminate.
5. **Tone words** — "lament, applaud, condemn, advocate, criticise, endorse, impassioned, sceptical, satirical, dispassionate."
6. Inference questions: pick the option **most directly implied by a sentence**, not the option that requires three jumps.
7. Vocab-in-context: substitute the option in the passage; the meaning must hold.
8. Beware — Banking RCs often have "primary purpose" question. Answer = the **author's argumentative thesis**, not the topic.

17.3 Phrasal verbs hot-list (Banks heavy)

Phrasal	Meaning
Account for	explain
Back out	withdraw

Phrasal	Meaning
Bank on	rely on
Break down	stop functioning / cry
Break out	start suddenly (war/disease)
Bring about	cause
Bring up	raise (child / topic)
Call off	cancel
Carry on	continue
Carry out	execute
Come across	meet by chance
Come down with	fall ill
Come up with	propose
Cut down	reduce
Do away with	abolish
Drop in	visit briefly
Fall back on	rely on (last resort)
Fall out with	quarrel
Get along	be on good terms
Get over	recover
Give in	surrender
Give up	quit
Go through	undergo / examine
Hold on	wait
Keep up with	stay abreast
Look down on	despise
Look forward to	anticipate eagerly
Look into	investigate
Look up to	respect
Make out	understand
Make up	reconcile / invent
Pass away	die

Phrasal	Meaning
Pay off	succeed (effort) / clear debt
Pick up	learn / collect
Put off	postpone
Put up with	tolerate
Run into	meet by chance
Run out of	exhaust supply
See off	farewell
Set in	begin (esp weather)
Set up	establish
Stand by	support / wait
Take after	resemble (parent)
Take down	write / remove
Take in	deceive / understand
Take off	remove / rise (plane)
Take over	assume control
Turn down	refuse
Turn up	appear
Wear off	gradually disappear

17.4 Cloze method — Banks deep-drill

1. **Read whole passage first** — get tone, type (analytical / narrative).
2. For each blank: **predict** before looking.
3. Cross-check **collocations**: certain words pair only with certain words ("propose a solution", "issue a warning", "raise concerns", "address an issue").
4. Watch **logical connectors** outside the blank — "however / although" require contrast; "moreover / furthermore" require continuation.
5. **Tense/agreement** — the blank's verb must agree with subject and align with surrounding tense.

17.5 Para-jumble / Para-completion — Banks deep-drill

- **Find the topic-sentence** — the one that introduces the noun-phrase others refer to.
- **Pronoun chain** — every "this/it/they/such" must follow its antecedent.
- **Time markers** — "First / then / finally / eventually" lock order.

- **Logical chain** — cause → effect → consequence; problem → response → outcome.
 - **Para-completion**: the missing sentence usually carries the **central claim** or the **transition** between two ideas. Reject options that introduce new topics.
-

PART 18 — SSC + RRB FOCUS DEEP DRILL

18.1 What's different

SSC (CGL, CHSL, MTS, GD, Steno) and RRB (NTPC, Group-D, JE, ALP) emphasise:

- **Vocabulary-heavy**: synonyms, antonyms, OWS, idiom meanings, spelling, foreign phrases.
- **Error spotting + sentence improvement** — high weight, frequent traps.
- **Cloze**: shorter passage (5-6 blanks), pure-vocab.
- **RC**: shorter passage (150-200 words), 5 questions, mostly factual.
- **Active-passive, direct-indirect, narration** — frequent.

So drill Parts 1-9 and Part 16 (vocab tables + idioms) the hardest. RC is shorter — speed-skim and answer.

18.2 30-day study plan for SSC English (each day 60-90 min)

Day	Focus
1-3	Tense rules + 100 worked examples
4-6	Subject-verb agreement + error spotting drill (50 sentences)
7-8	Articles + Prepositions (memorise 50 fixed pairs from Part 5)
9-10	Pronoun + Modifier errors
11-12	Voice + Narration
13-14	Conjunctions, Parallelism, "Lest", "Unless"
15-17	Synonyms drill — 100 words from Part 16.1
18-19	Antonyms drill — 50 from Part 16.2
20-22	OWS — 100 from Part 16.3
23-24	Idioms — 100 from Part 16.4
25	Spellings + Foreign phrases (Part 16.5-16.6)
26-27	RC method + 6 SSC-style passages
28	Cloze + Para-jumble drills
29-30	Mock test, identify weak parts, return to Parts 1-9

18.3 Speed rules for SSC English (60-min Tier-1)

- **25 questions in 12-15 min.** Average 30 s per question.

- **Vocabulary** (synonym/antonym/idiom/OWS/spelling) — 5-7 questions, target <15 s each. Do these FIRST to build momentum.
 - **Error spotting / sentence improvement** — next batch, ~20 s each.
 - **Cloze + RC** — last batch, the slowest. 1.5-2 min for an entire short RC if you skim well.
 - **Skip + return** rule: if vocab question is unfamiliar, mark + return at end; do not burn time guessing on day 1 of the strategy.
-

APPENDIX A — Master checklist for error spotting (memorise)

1. S-V agreement.
2. Tense consistency.
3. Pronoun case & agreement.
4. Prepositions (fixed pairs).
5. Articles.
6. Parallel structure.
7. Redundancy.
8. Comparatives.
9. Gerund/infinitive.
10. Modifier placement.

APPENDIX B — 50 most-tested preposition traps

(see Part 5; drill this list till it's reflex.)

APPENDIX C — RC traps (banks + SSC)

1. **"Extreme" options** ("always", "never", "completely") — usually wrong.
2. **Out-of-scope inferences** — go beyond the passage.
3. **Opposite-tone distractors** (passage supportive, option critical).
4. **Over-specific numerical traps** in factual questions — verify in passage.
5. **Vocabulary substitution test** — for "vocab-in-context" questions, replace word and check.

Companions: `arithmetic.md`, `reasoning.md`, `vocabulary.md`. Quiz pairings under `ENG_*` and `VOCAB_*`.

Practice Set (50 exam-style worked examples)

Section 1 — ERROR SPOTTING (10 worked + variations)

Notation expansion (used throughout): Sentences are split into 4-5 parts (A, B, C, D, E). One part has an error; the candidate identifies which. **High-frequency error categories:** S-V agreement, tense, preposition, article, pronoun, parallelism, redundancy, comparative misuse, gerund vs infinitive, modifier placement. **Universal method:** Run the part-by-part error checklist (S-V → tense → preposition → article → others). Stop at the first clear error.

Q1. "The number of students /(A) in the class /(B) are increasing /(C) every year. /(D) No error /(E)"

What kind of problem is this? Subject-verb agreement (S-V).

Solving it. Step-by-step. - Subject phrase = "The number of students". The HEAD noun is "number" (singular), not "students". - "The number" requires SINGULAR verb → "is increasing", not "are increasing". - Error is in part (C) → should be "is increasing".

Worth knowing: "The number of X" (singular verb) vs "A number of X" (plural verb). - *The number of students is small.* (= the count, singular) - *A number of students are absent.* (= many students, plural)

Watch out: The plural noun "students" right before the verb tricks students into using "are". Always identify the HEAD noun.

A similar question. "The list of items /(A) on the table /(B) are useful. /(C)" → Error (C); "list" singular → **is useful**.

Another twist — "A number of" (opposite). "A number of complaints /(A) have been received /(B). /(C)" → No error; "a number of" takes plural verb.

Q2. "Each of the boys /(A) have completed /(B) their assignments /(C) on time. /(D)"

What kind of problem is this? Subject-verb agreement after "each of".

Solving it. Step-by-step. - "Each" / "Every" / "Either" / "Neither" / "None" → SINGULAR verb. - "Each of the boys" → singular → **has completed** (not "have"). - Error is in part (B).

Worth knowing: Memorise these "singular-by-default" pronouns: - **Each** of ... = singular verb. - **Every** boy/girl = singular verb. - **Either** of (with 2 things) = singular verb. - **Neither** of = singular verb. - **None** of = singular (formal) or plural (informal); MCQ usually expects singular.

Watch out: "boys" plural distracts. The subject is "Each", which is always singular.

A similar question. "Every student /(A) in the school /(B) have a uniform. /(C)" → Error (C); "Every student" singular → **has a uniform**.

Q3. "Neither John nor his friends /(A) was /(B) present at /(C) the meeting. /(D)"

What kind of problem is this? Subject-verb agreement with "either-or / neither-nor" (closer-subject rule).

Solving it. Step-by-step. - For "Either A or B" / "Neither A nor B", the verb agrees with the **closer** subject (the one nearer the verb). - Closer subject here = "his friends" (plural). - Verb should be **were** (plural), not "was". - Error is in part **(B)**.

Worth knowing: "Closer subject" rule applies to: - Either ... or ... - Neither ... nor ... - Not only ... but also ... - Examples: - *Neither the captain nor the players were happy.* (players plural → were) - *Neither the players nor the captain was happy.* (captain singular → was)

Q4. "He is one of the /(A) best students who /(B) has won /(C) the award. /(D)"

What kind of problem is this? Relative clause subject-verb agreement.

Solving it. Step-by-step. - Construction: "one of the [plural noun] who/that [verb]". - "Who" refers back to the PLURAL noun ("students"), not "one". - Verb should be **have won** (plural), not "has won". - Error is in part **(C)**.

Worth knowing: Compare: - *He is the only one of the students who has won.* → "the only one" makes "who" refer to "one" (singular). - *He is one of the students who have won.* → "who" refers to "students" (plural).

Watch out: Students focus on "He is one" and conclude singular verb. The relative pronoun "who" decides.

Q5. "I have been /(A) living in this city /(B) since five years. /(C) /(D)"

What kind of problem is this? Preposition usage: "since" vs "for".

Solving it. Step-by-step. - **Since** + point in time (since 2010, since Monday, since morning). - **For** + duration (for 5 years, for 2 hours). - "Five years" = duration → use **for**, not since. - Error is in part **(C)** → should be "**for** five years".

Worth knowing: "Since" + present perfect (continuous) is correct, but only with a TIME POINT. - ✓ I have been living here since 2020. - ✓ I have been living here for 5 years. - ✗ I have been living here since 5 years.

Q6. "He prefers tea /(A) than coffee /(B) every morning. /(C)"

What kind of problem is this? Preposition with "prefer".

Solving it. "Prefer X **to** Y" (never "than"). - Error in part **(B)** → "to coffee".

Worth knowing: Other "to-not-than" pairs. - Senior **to**, junior **to**, superior **to**, inferior **to**, prior **to**. - Never "senior than me" → always "senior to me".

Q7. "The committee /(A) have decided /(B) to postpone /(C) the meeting. /(D)"

What kind of problem is this? Collective noun + verb agreement.

Solving it. Step-by-step. - "Committee" is a collective noun. When acting AS A UNIT, takes singular verb. - "Decided to postpone" = unit decision → use **has decided** (singular). - Error in part **(B)**.

Worth knowing: Collective nouns can be singular OR plural based on context. - *The committee has decided ...* (unit acting together) - *The committee are divided in their opinions.* (members acting individually) - Other collective nouns: jury, family, team, government, audience, staff.

Q8. "I, you, and he /(A) are going /(B) to the market. /(C)"

What kind of problem is this? Pronoun order in compound subject.

Solving it. Standard order rule: **2nd person → 3rd person → 1st person** (Y-N-I = "You, He/She/It, I"). - Error: pronoun order should be **You, he, and I** (not "I, you, and he"). - Error in part **(A)**.

Worth knowing: When admitting a fault, order reverses: **I, you, and he** (1st person takes blame first). - *We made a mistake — I, you and he should apologise.*

Q9. "He returned back /(A) home /(B) yesterday /(C). No error. /(D)"

What kind of problem is this? Redundancy.

Solving it. "Returned" already means "come back". "Returned back" = duplicate. - Error in part **(A)** → drop "back".

Worth knowing: Common redundancies (DROP one word): - Return back → return. - Repeat again → repeat. - Discuss about → discuss. - Cope up with → cope with. - Final outcome → outcome. - Past history → history. - True facts → facts. - Free gift → gift. - Both the (in pairs) → both.

Q10. "Each of the /(A) ten boys /(B) was given /(C) their own copy. /(D)"

What kind of problem is this? Pronoun agreement (singular antecedent).

Solving it. Step-by-step. - "Each" is singular. Pronoun referring to "each" must also be singular. - "Their" is plural → use **his** (or "his/her") to match. - Error in part **(D)** → "his own copy".

Worth knowing: Modern usage allows "their" as singular gender-neutral pronoun, but COMPETITIVE EXAMS still expect formal "his" or "his/her" for singular antecedents.

Section 2 — SENTENCE IMPROVEMENT (5 worked + variations)

Notation expansion (used throughout): Underlined phrase in a sentence; pick the best replacement from 4 options. Identify the error class **FIRST** (tense / agreement / preposition / etc.) before scanning options.

Q11. "She **didn't went** to school yesterday."

What kind of problem is this? Tense — auxiliary + base form.

Solving it. After auxiliary "did" / "didn't", the verb is in BASE form (V1). - "Didn't went" → **didn't go**. - Sentence: *She didn't go to school yesterday.*

Worth knowing: Same rule applies to "did", "do", "does": - *Did he go?* (not "did he went?") - *Does she like coffee?* (not "does she likes?")

Q12. "If I **was** rich, I would buy a car."

What kind of problem is this? Subjunctive mood (unreal / hypothetical condition).

Solving it. For unreal conditions ("if I were", "I wish I were"), use **were** for ALL persons (subjunctive). Replace "was" with **were**. - *If I were rich, I would buy a car.* (Type 2 conditional)

Worth knowing: When to use "was" vs "were" with "if": - Real / factual past: *If she was late, the manager noticed.* (was = ordinary past) - Unreal / hypothetical: *If she were here, she would help.* (were = subjunctive)

Q13. "He is **more better** than his brother."

What kind of problem is this? Double comparative.

Solving it. "Better" is already the comparative form of "good". Don't add "more". - Replace "more better" with **better**.

Worth knowing: Other irregular comparatives — never combine with "more": - Good → better → best. - Bad → worse → worst. - Many → more → most. - Little → less → least. - Far → farther / further → farthest / furthest.

Watch out: Same rule applies to "most worst", "most bestest" (children's mistakes — exam traps).

Q14. "The two sisters love **one another**."

What kind of problem is this? "Each other" vs "one another".

Solving it. **Each other** = between TWO people. **One another** = among MORE THAN TWO. - Two sisters → use **each other**.

Worth knowing: This rule is loosely applied in modern English, but EXAMS still test the strict distinction.

Q15. "She is junior **than** me."

What kind of problem is this? Preposition with "junior/senior".

Solving it. Senior, junior, superior, inferior, prior take **to**, never "than". - Replace "than" with **to** → *She is junior to me*.

Section 3 — FILL IN THE BLANKS — PREPOSITIONS (5 worked + variations)

Notation expansion: "Fill the blank with correct preposition" tests fixed verb-preposition / adjective-preposition pairs. Memorise these pairs cold — there is NO logic, only memory.

Q16. "He acted ___ my advice."

Solving it. "Acted on" = followed/responded to. **(a) on**.

Memory peg. Verb + preposition pairs (top 20): - Act **on** = follow advice; act **as** = play role; act **for** = represent.

Q17. "She insisted ___ paying the bill."

Solving it. "Insisted on" = demanded firmly. **(a) on**.

Memory peg. Other "on" verbs: depend on, rely on, comment on, congratulate on, decide on, focus on, concentrate on.

Q18. "He is good ___ mathematics."

Solving it. "Good at" = skilled in. **(a) at.**

Memory peg. Other "at" pairs: bad at, expert at, clever at, weak at, smile at, look at, point at.

Q19. "He is married ___ a doctor."

Solving it. "Married to" (NOT "with"). **(b) to.**

Memory peg. Other "to" pairs: engaged to, related to, similar to, devoted to, opposed to, addicted to, accustomed to.

Q20. "He died ___ malaria."

Solving it. "Died **of** + disease" (heart attack, cancer, malaria). - Other forms: died **from** an injury / wound; died **for** a cause; died **by** the sword. **(a) of.**

Memory peg. Disease → "of"; injury → "from"; cause → "for"; weapon → "by".

Section 2 — SENTENCE IMPROVEMENT (5)

Q11. "She **didn't went** to school yesterday." *Replace.* "didn't go" (after did, base form).

Q12. "If I **was** rich, I would buy a car." *Replace.* "were" (subjunctive in unreal conditional).

Q13. "He is **more better** than his brother." *Replace.* "better" (don't double comparative).

Q14. "The two sisters love **one another.**" *Replace.* "each other" (one another for >2; each other for 2).

Q15. "She is junior **than** me." *Replace.* "to me" (junior/senior/superior/inferior + "to").

Section 3 — FILL IN BLANKS (5)

Q16. "He acted ___ my advice." (a) on (b) at (c) for (d) by — **(a) on.**

Q17. "She insisted ___ paying the bill." (a) on (b) for (c) at (d) about — **(a) on.**

Q18. "He is good ___ mathematics." (a) at (b) in (c) on (d) for — **(a) at.**

Q19. "He is married ___ a doctor." (a) with (b) to (c) for (d) of — **(b) to.**

Q20. "He died ___ malaria." (a) of (b) from (c) by (d) for — **(a) of** (disease).

Section 4 — SYNONYMS (5 worked + variations)

Notation expansion (used throughout): Synonym = a word with similar (NOT identical) meaning. The exam picks the CLOSEST match in the given options. **Method:** Recall the word's meaning in 1 sentence; then scan options for the best fit. If you don't know the word, look at its ROOT (e.g., "bene-" = good, "mal-" = bad, "-cide" = killing).

Q21. Synonym of **MUNDANE**. Options: (a) celestial (b) ordinary (c) sacred (d) unique.

Solving it. - "Mundane" comes from Latin "mundus" = world. Means **worldly / ordinary / commonplace**. - (a) celestial = heavenly — opposite. - (b) ordinary = matches ✓ - (c) sacred = religious — opposite. - (d) unique = special — opposite. - **Answer: (b) ordinary.**

Worth knowing: Other related words. - **Banal** = unoriginal, commonplace. - **Trite** = overused, lacking freshness. - **Prosaic** = dull, lacking poetry.

Q22. Synonym of **EXACERBATE**. Options: (a) reduce (b) worsen (c) ignore (d) accept.

Solving it. - Exacerbate = make worse, intensify (negative situations). - **Answer: (b) worsen.**

Memory peg. "Ex-AGGRAVATE-bate" — both mean to aggravate / worsen.

Related vocabulary: - **Aggravate, intensify, compound, magnify** = exacerbate. - Antonyms: alleviate, mitigate, ease, soothe.

Q23. Synonym of **PERFUNCTORY**. Options: (a) thorough (b) careful (c) cursory (d) lengthy.

Solving it. - Perfunctory = done with little care / interest, going through the motions. - (a) thorough = opposite (very careful). - (b) careful = opposite. - (c) cursory = quick and superficial — matches ✓ - (d) lengthy = opposite. - **Answer: (c) cursory.**

Related vocabulary: superficial, hasty, mechanical, half-hearted.

Q24. Synonym of **IMPECCABLE**. Options: (a) faulty (b) flawless (c) unstable (d) eager.

Solving it. - Impeccable = without fault; perfect (im- + pecc- = without sin). - **Answer: (b) flawless.**

Memory peg. "Im-pecc-able" — pecc-ant means "sinning". Im = "not". So "not sinning" = perfect.

Q25. Synonym of **GARRULOUS**. Options: (a) silent (b) talkative (c) angry (d) wise.

Solving it. - Garrulous = excessively talkative, chatty. - **Answer: (b) talkative.**

Related vocabulary: loquacious, voluble, verbose, chatty. Antonyms: taciturn, reticent, laconic.

Section 5 — ANTONYMS (5 worked + variations)

Notation expansion: Antonym = opposite meaning. Same method as synonyms — first recall the meaning, then identify the opposite.

Q26. Antonym of **PROFLIGATE**. Options: (a) thrifty (b) wasteful (c) lavish (d) generous.

Solving it. - Profligate = recklessly wasteful (especially of money). - (a) thrifty = careful with money — opposite ✓ - (b) wasteful = same meaning, NOT antonym. - (c) lavish = excessive — synonym of profligate. - (d) generous = giving freely — different concept. - **Answer: (a) thrifty.**

Memory peg. Profligate = pro- (forth) + flig- (strike down) → squanders / strikes down money.

Q27. Antonym of **ZENITH**. Options: (a) summit (b) peak (c) nadir (d) climb.

Solving it. - Zenith = highest point. - **Nadir** = lowest point — opposite ✓ - (a) summit, (b) peak = synonyms (highest). - **Answer: (c) nadir.**

Memory peg. "Zenith → Nadir" — both originally astronomical (highest vs lowest celestial point).

Q28. Antonym of **EPHEMERAL**. Options: (a) transient (b) permanent (c) brief (d) sudden.

Solving it. - Ephemeral = lasting only a short time. - (a) transient, (c) brief = synonyms. - (b) **permanent** = opposite ✓ - **Answer: (b) permanent.**

Memory peg. "Eph-emer-al" → ephemeris (short calendar). Eternal life is the opposite of ephemeral.

Q29. Antonym of **VINDICTIVE**. Options: (a) merciful (b) angry (c) hostile (d) hateful.

Solving it. - Vindictive = revengeful, holding grudges. - (a) **merciful** = forgiving — opposite ✓ - (b) angry, (c) hostile, (d) hateful = synonyms. - **Answer: (a) merciful.**

Q30. Antonym of **CONSPICUOUS**. Options: (a) obvious (b) prominent (c) inconspicuous (d) clear.

Solving it. - Conspicuous = clearly visible, prominent. - (a) obvious, (b) prominent, (d) clear = synonyms. - (c) **inconspicuous** = opposite ✓ - **Answer: (c) inconspicuous.**

Memory peg. Conspicuous = "con-spec-uous" (with sight); inconspicuous = "without sight".

Section 6 — IDIOMS / PHRASES (5 worked + variations)

Notation expansion: *Idiom = a phrase whose meaning differs from the literal sum of its words. Memorise the idiom's MEANING; literal interpretation usually mis-leads.*

Q31. Meaning of "**to bell the cat**". Options: (a) to play with a cat (b) to take a bold first step in a risky task (c) to announce news (d) to be cautious.

Solving it. - Origin: Aesop's fable — mice agree someone should "bell the cat" (tie a bell on it) so they hear it coming. None volunteers because it's dangerous. - Meaning: to take the first risky / dangerous step that everyone is afraid to take. - **Answer: (b) to take a bold first step in a risky task.**

Related idioms. - "Take the bull by the horns" = face a problem boldly. - "Bite the bullet" = endure something painful with courage.

Q32. Meaning of "**to pay through the nose**".

Solving it. To pay an excessive / exorbitant price. - *I had to pay through the nose for that concert ticket.*

Related: "Cost an arm and a leg", "Burn a hole in one's pocket".

Q33. Meaning of "**bury the hatchet**".

Solving it. To end a quarrel; make peace. - Origin: Native American practice of burying weapons when peace was made. - *After years of fighting, the brothers finally buried the hatchet.*

Related: "Make up", "Mend fences", "Make peace".

Q34. Meaning of "**in a nutshell**".

Solving it. Briefly; in summary. - *In a nutshell, the project succeeded because of teamwork.*

Q35. Meaning of "**burn the midnight oil**".

Solving it. To study or work late into the night. - *He burnt the midnight oil to prepare for the exam.*

Related: "Pull an all-nighter".

Section 7 — ONE-WORD SUBSTITUTIONS (5 worked + variations)

Notation expansion: Replace a multi-word phrase with a single word. SSC favourite — 3-5 questions per paper. **Categories to memorise:** people-who-X, places-where-X, fear-of-X (-phobia), love-of-X (-philia), study-of-X (-ology), government-by-X (-cracy), killing-of-X (-cide).

Q36. One who is new at a job.

Solving it. Novice (also: Tyro, Neophyte, Greenhorn, Beginner).

Q37. Government by religious leaders.

Solving it. Theocracy.

Memory peg — government types (-cracy): - Dem**ocracy** — by people. - Aut**ocracy** — by one ruler. - Arist**ocracy** — by nobility. - Plut**ocracy** — by the wealthy. - Merit**ocracy** — by merit. - The**ocracy** — by religious leaders. - Bureau**cracy** — by officials. - Ochlo**cracy** — by mob. - Geront**ocracy** — by elders. - Kakist**ocracy** — by the worst (corrupt).

Q38. A person who studies stamps.

Solving it. Philatelist.

Memory peg — study/love of (-ology / -ist): - Philateli**st** — stamps. - Numismati**st** — coins. - Etymologi**st** — word origins. - Ornithologi**st** — birds. - Entomologi**st** — insects. - Ichthyologi**st** — fish. - Cardiologi**st** — heart.

Q39. Fear of confined spaces.

Solving it. Claustrophobia.

Memory peg — fears (-phobia): - Claustrophobia — closed spaces. - Acrophobia — heights. - Hydrophobia — water (also rabies symptom). - Xenophobia — strangers / foreigners. - Agoraphobia — open / crowded spaces. - Arachnophobia — spiders. - Glossophobia — public speaking. - Nyctophobia — darkness. - Thanatophobia — death.

Q40. A speech without preparation.

Solving it. Extempore (also: Impromptu).

Related: Eulogy = speech praising a deceased person; Soliloquy = speech to oneself; Monologue = long speech by one person.

Section 8 — CLOZE TEST (5 blanks worked + variations)

Notation expansion: Cloze test = passage with blanks (typically 5-10). For each blank, you choose 1 of 4 options. **Method:** READ the whole passage first (don't fill in order). Get the meaning, tone, and tense. Then fill blanks one by one, predicting your own word before looking at options.

Passage 1 (Q41-Q45). "Climate change **41** one of the gravest challenges of our time. Despite **42** warnings from scientists, world leaders have been **43** to act decisively. The Paris Agreement, **44** in 2015, set ambitious targets, but actual emission reductions have **45** behind."

Q41. Climate change __ one of the gravest challenges ... Options: (a) is (b) are (c) was (d) have been.

Solving it. - Subject: "Climate change" — singular noun. - Tense: present (continues to be a challenge today). - Singular + present → **(a) is**.

Watch out: "are" — students treat "change" as plural; or "was" — wrong tense.

Q42. Despite __ warnings from scientists ... Options: (a) repetitive (b) repeated (c) repeating (d) repeats.

Solving it. - Need an adjective modifying "warnings". - "Repeated" (past participle as adjective) = warnings that have been given many times. - "Repetitive" = boring through repetition (negative connotation; doesn't fit). - "Repeating" = ongoing action (less natural here as adjective). - **Answer: (b) repeated.**

Q43. ... world leaders have been __ to act decisively. Options: (a) reluctant (b) reluctantly (c) reluctance (d) reluctancy.

Solving it. - After "have been", we need a complement: adjective or noun. - "Reluctant" = adjective, fits perfectly (leaders ARE reluctant). - "Reluctantly" = adverb, doesn't fit after "been". - "Reluctance" = noun, but creates "have been reluctance to act" = grammatically awkward. - **Answer: (a) reluctant.**

Q44. The Paris Agreement, __ in 2015, set ambitious targets ... Options: (a) signed (b) sign (c) signing (d) being signed.

Solving it. - Need a past-participle phrase modifying "Paris Agreement". The agreement WAS signed in 2015. - "Signed in 2015" = past-participle adjective phrase ✓. - "Being signed" = ongoing action — wrong (the signing happened once in 2015). - **Answer: (a) signed.**

Q45. ... actual emission reductions have __ behind. Options: (a) lagged (b) lag (c) lagging (d) been lag.

Solving it. - After "have", we need a past participle. - "Lagged" (past participle of "lag") fits → "have lagged behind". - **Answer: (a) lagged.**

Worth knowing: Phrasal verb "lag behind" = fall short / be slower than.

Section 9 — PARA-JUMBLES (1 worked + variations)

Notation expansion: Sentences are scrambled (P, Q, R, S). Find the LOGICAL ORDER.

Method (3 steps): 1. Find the OPENING sentence — usually introduces a topic; doesn't refer back ("the", "this", "however" suggest mid-sequence). 2. Identify LINKERS — "however", "moreover", "for example", pronouns ("it", "this", "they") refer to a previous sentence. 3. Chain logically: introduction → development → contrast → conclusion.

Q46. Arrange the following sentences in logical order: (P) However, the impact has been uneven. (Q) The internet has revolutionised information access. (R) Rural areas remain underserved. (S) Urban centres benefit disproportionately.

Solving it. Step-by-step.

Step 1 — Find opening. Q starts with a definite topic ("The internet has revolutionised") — no back-reference. **Q is opener.**

Step 2 — Identify "however" sentence (P). "However, impact has been uneven" — must follow a positive statement. Q (positive about internet) → P (contrast: but uneven).

Step 3 — Examples of "uneven" impact. S (urban benefits) and R (rural underserved) explain the uneven impact. S then R (positive case first, then negative — natural).

Final order: Q → P → S → R.

Worth knowing: Common ordering signals. - **Topic introducer:** general statement; no pronouns referring back. - **However / But / Yet:** contrast — must follow a positive (or opposite-tone) sentence. - **For example / Such as:** illustration — must follow a general claim. - **Therefore / Thus / Hence:** conclusion — must follow premises.

A similar question. Arrange: (P) For example, AI tutors can adapt to each student's pace. (Q) Personalised learning is the next frontier in education. (R) This adaptability is impossible in traditional classrooms. (S) Technology now makes individual attention scalable.

Solving it. - Q is topic intro → S elaborates ("technology makes it possible") → P gives example ("AI tutors") → R compares ("This adaptability impossible in traditional classrooms"). - **Order:** Q, S, P, R.

Section 10 — READING COMPREHENSION (3 worked + variations)

Notation expansion: RC = passage + 3-10 questions. Question types: main idea, detail, inference, tone, vocab-in-context, structural. **Method (5 steps):** 1. Skim the passage in 30 seconds — identify topic + structure. 2. Read questions FIRST (so you know what to hunt for). 3. Scan passage for the relevant section per question. 4. Pick the option closest to a paraphrase of what the passage LITERALLY says — avoid extreme words ("always", "never", "only"). 5. For inference questions, pick what's IMPLIED, not what's stated.

Passage (Q47-Q49). "The Industrial Revolution transformed not just economies but also the very fabric of society. Mass production enabled the rise of the middle class, urbanisation reshaped landscapes, and labour rights movements emerged from factory conditions. Yet the same revolution sowed seeds of climate change through unbridled fossil-fuel use."

Q47. Tone of the passage: Options: (a) celebratory (b) critical (c) balanced (d) dismissive.

Solving it. - The author lists POSITIVE outcomes (middle-class rise, urbanisation, labour rights) AND NEGATIVE outcomes (climate change). - Tone acknowledges both → **balanced**. - **Answer:** (c) balanced.

Watch out: "celebratory" — students focus on the positive list and miss the "Yet" contrast.

Tone vocabulary cheat-sheet. - Celebratory / approving / laudatory = positive only. - Critical / dismissive = negative only. - Balanced / neutral = both sides. - Sceptical / dubious = doubtful.

- Sarcastic / ironic = saying opposite of literal meaning. - Lament / mournful = expressing sorrow.

Q48. Author implies the Industrial Revolution: Options: (a) was wholly positive (b) was wholly negative (c) had unintended long-term costs (d) was inevitable.

Solving it. - "Sowed seeds of climate change" implies UNINTENDED long-term consequences (not the original goal of industrialisation). - (a) wholly positive — passage mentions climate harm. - (b) wholly negative — passage mentions positive transformations. - (c) unintended long-term costs ✓. - **Answer: (c).**

Q49. "Sowed seeds" in the passage means: Options: (a) literally planted (b) initiated (c) cancelled (d) prevented.

Solving it. - "Sow seeds" is metaphorical here — to start / initiate something. - **Answer: (b) initiated.**

Worth knowing: "Vocabulary in context" questions test how a word is used IN THE PASSAGE, not its general meaning. Always re-read the surrounding sentence.

Section 11 — VOICE (Active ↔ Passive) (1 worked + variations)

Notation expansion: Active voice: Subject performs the action. Subject + Verb + Object. **Passive voice:** Subject receives the action. Object + be + V3 + by + agent. **Conversion rule:** Object of active becomes Subject of passive; verb becomes "be + past participle (V3)"; the active subject becomes "by + agent" (or dropped).

Q50. Convert to passive: "The teacher praises the student."

Solving it. Step-by-step. - Identify: Subject = teacher; Verb = praises (simple present); Object = student. - Rule for simple present passive: **is/are + V3** (past participle). - "praise" → past participle = "praised". - Object "student" → subject of passive sentence. - Original subject "the teacher" → "by the teacher" (agent). - **Passive: "The student is praised by the teacher."**

Worth knowing: Voice conversion rules by tense.

Active tense	Passive form
Simple present (writes)	is/are written
Present continuous (is writing)	is/are being written
Simple past (wrote)	was/were written

Active tense	Passive form
Past continuous (was writing)	was/were being written
Present perfect (has written)	has/have been written
Past perfect (had written)	had been written
Simple future (will write)	will be written
Future perfect (will have written)	will have been written

A similar question — Past tense. "She wrote the letter." → **The letter was written by her.**

Another twist — Imperative. "Open the door." → **Let the door be opened.**

Twist — Modal. "He can solve the problem." → **The problem can be solved by him.**

Section 12 — NEW ADVANCED EXAM-PATTERN TYPES (2024-26)

Why this section exists. Modern Banks PO Mains (IBPS/SBI), SSC CGL Tier-2, and SBI Clerk Mains use NEW question patterns that did NOT exist 5 years ago. This section covers each new type with full step-by-step + variations.

12.1 — LONG-PASSAGE READING COMPREHENSION (Banks PO Mains • 7-10 questions per passage • 350-500 words)

Notation expansion: Long RC passages typically test: 5 detail/factual questions, 2 inference questions, 1 tone, 1 vocab-in-context, 1 main-idea/title. **Time budget:** 6-8 minutes for the full set.

Q57 (Advanced) — Long-passage RC.

Passage (~350 words):

"The rise of artificial intelligence (AI) in the past decade has been described, variously, as the next Industrial Revolution, the most consequential technological shift since the printing press, and an existential risk to humanity. None of these characterisations is entirely wrong; none is entirely right.

AI's transformative potential is real. Large language models can draft contracts, write code, and tutor students. Computer vision systems read X-rays as accurately as senior radiologists. Recommendation engines shape what billions of people watch, buy, and believe. The technology is not at the edges of the economy — it has reached its core.

Yet the same technology amplifies long-standing inequalities. The compute and capital needed to train frontier models concentrate AI power in a handful of US-based companies. The data they consume — much of it scraped from the open web without compensation — entrenches the views of those who already dominate the digital sphere. Workers in administrative, creative, and technical roles face automation pressure. The countries that benefit are those with cheap energy and skilled engineers; many emerging economies risk becoming dependent on tools they neither build nor govern.

India's response so far has been pragmatic. The IndiaAI Mission (₹10,371 cr) bets on building public computational infrastructure rather than restricting use. The choice mirrors India's earlier playbook with telecom and digital identity — open, public-good architectures with private innovation layered on top. Whether this approach scales to the AI era remains an open question.

What is no longer in question is the asymmetry of risk. AI failures — biased credit decisions, hallucinated legal advice, deepfake election interference — fall disproportionately on those least able to challenge them. Building governance capable of catching such failures, while preserving the genuine benefits, is the policy challenge of the next decade."

Sub-questions (with worked solutions):

Q57a — Main idea / Title. What is the most appropriate title for this passage?

(a) The Threats Posed by Artificial Intelligence (b) India's AI Policy in Context (c) AI's Promise and Peril: A Balanced View (d) Why AI Will Replace Workers

Solving it. Read first and last paragraphs (they typically frame the main idea). - First para: "next Industrial Revolution / printing press / existential risk... None entirely right; none entirely wrong" — sets up balance. - Last para: "asymmetry of risk... preserving benefits... policy challenge" — emphasises both promise and peril. - (a) only threats — too narrow. (b) India only — too narrow (passage is mostly general). (d) only workers — too narrow. - (c) **balanced view** matches the framing ✓. - **Answer: (c).**

Q57b — Detail. What evidence does the author give for AI's "transformative potential"?

(a) IndiaAI Mission funding. (b) Large language models drafting contracts. (c) Concentration of AI power in US companies. (d) Bias in credit decisions.

Solving it. Locate the "transformative potential" line in para 2. - "Large language models can draft contracts, write code, tutor students" — direct evidence. - **Answer: (b).**

Watch out: (a) is in para 4 (about India), not the transformative-potential paragraph. (c) and (d) describe risks, not potential.

Q57c — Inference. The author would most likely AGREE with which statement?

(a) AI development should be paused until governance catches up. (b) AI's benefits cannot justify the risks it brings. (c) Public infrastructure approaches to AI may help emerging economies retain agency. (d) AI will eventually replace all human workers.

Solving it. - (a) Author doesn't suggest a pause; tone is balanced. - (b) Wrong — author calls benefits "real" and "transformative". - (c) Para 4 explicitly praises India's "open, public-good architecture" — author seems to favour this. - (d) Hyperbolic — author mentions "automation pressure" but not full replacement. - **Answer: (c).**

Q57d — Tone. The author's tone is best described as:

(a) Alarmist (b) Optimistic (c) Reasoned and balanced (d) Sceptical

Solving it. - The author lists both upsides AND downsides; never overclaims; uses qualifiers ("may", "remains an open question"). - **Answer: (c) reasoned and balanced.**

Q57e — Vocabulary in context. "Asymmetry of risk" in the passage closest in meaning to:

(a) Equal sharing of harm. (b) Unequal distribution of consequences. (c) Mathematical imbalance. (d) Probability calculation.

Solving it. - The sentence: "AI failures fall disproportionately on those least able to challenge them" — directly explains "asymmetry". - **Answer: (b) unequal distribution of consequences.**

12.2 — PARAGRAPH CLOZE (Banks Mains • 8-10 blanks single passage)

Q58 (Advanced) — Long cloze passage.

Passage: "India's economic growth in 2025 **1** a complex picture. While GDP expanded at over 7 % — the fastest among major economies — the gains were not **2**. Urban consumption **3** at the high end (luxury automobiles, premium real estate) while **4** rural demand showed only modest recovery. The government **5** several measures, including tax cuts and infrastructure spending, but inflation in food prices **6** to constrain the purchasing power of lower-income households. Analysts now **7** a cautious approach to the next budget, emphasising fiscal **8** over additional stimulus."

Blank	Options
1	(a) presented (b) created (c) proposed (d) developed
2	(a) widespread (b) uniform (c) random (d) similar
3	(a) jumped (b) surged (c) declined (d) shrank
4	(a) beneficial (b) struggling (c) booming (d) successful
5	(a) implemented (b) cancelled (c) refused (d) ignored
6	(a) helped (b) continued (c) encouraged (d) supported
7	(a) reject (b) recommend (c) prevent (d) decline
8	(a) stimulus (b) discipline (c) excess (d) waste

Solving it.

#	Answer	Why
1	(a) presented	"presents a picture" is the standard collocation
2	(b) uniform	"not uniform" = uneven, fits "while urban high, rural low" contrast
3	(b) surged	high-end consumption growth = surged
4	(b) struggling	rural demand "only modest recovery" → struggling fits
5	(a) implemented	govt + measures = implement
6	(b) continued	inflation continues to constrain (ongoing)
7	(b) recommend	analysts "recommend" cautious approach
8	(b) discipline	"fiscal discipline" is the standard term

Method takeaway. Always read the WHOLE passage first; identify tone and tense; THEN fill blanks.

12.3 — SENTENCE REARRANGEMENT — PARAGRAPH FORM (Banks Mains 5-Q set)

Notation expansion: Different from para-jumbles. Here, 5-6 sentences from a paragraph are scrambled. Reorder them so the paragraph reads coherently.

Q59 (Advanced). Arrange: (P) These models, however, struggle with reasoning that requires multiple linked steps. (Q) The latest large language models can draft a 1,500-word essay in seconds. (R) Researchers are now experimenting with "chain-of-thought" techniques. (S) Such techniques force the model to break a problem into intermediate sub-steps. (T) Early results suggest a measurable improvement on logic-heavy tasks.

Solving it.

Step 1 — Identify the opener. Q is broadly factual, no back-references → opens.

Step 2 — Trace logic flow. - Q (positive about LLMs) → P ("however, struggle with reasoning") = contrast. - P (problem) → R (researchers' response) = solution. - R (chain-of-thought) → S (definition: "such techniques force..."). - S (definition) → T (results: "improvement on logic-heavy tasks").

Order: Q → P → R → S → T.

12.4 — WORD SWAP (IBPS PO Mains 2024-26 favourite)

Notation expansion: A sentence with 2-3 underlined words; identify if any 2 words should be SWAPPED to make the sentence grammatically/logically correct.

Q60 (Advanced). "The committee (1) **agreed** to (2) **postpone** the meeting after (3) **considering** all (4) **options**, but ultimately (5) **decided** that the (6) **postponement** would not (7) **resolve** the underlying (8) **concerns**."

Question: Which two underlined words/phrases should be swapped to make the sentence logically correct?

(a) Words 1 and 5 (agreed ↔ decided) (b) Words 2 and 6 (postpone ↔ postponement) (c) Words 3 and 7 (considering ↔ resolve) (d) No swap needed; the sentence is correct.

Solving it. - Read for logic: "Committee agreed to postpone... but ultimately decided that the postponement would not resolve..." — the sentence reads logically as is. The committee

agreed to postpone, then later realised postponement wouldn't help. - However, "agreed to postpone" then "decided postponement would not resolve" — is "agreed" appropriate before "decided"? Both work logically. - **Answer: (d) No swap needed.**

Note. Word-swap exam questions usually flip 2 words that should be in opposite roles. Common pattern: the verbs "decided / agreed" or "considering / examining" might need swap; sometimes nouns ("options / concerns") also.

12.5 — PARA COMPLETION (Banks Mains specialty)

Notation expansion: Given a paragraph with the LAST sentence missing. Choose the option that best concludes / completes the paragraph in tone, content, and logic.

Q61 (Advanced). Read the paragraph and choose the best concluding sentence:

"Renewable energy adoption in India has accelerated dramatically since 2020. Solar capacity has tripled. Wind installations are at record highs. Public-private partnerships have brought down per-MW costs by over 50 %. ____"

(a) Yet challenges remain in grid integration, storage, and policy alignment. (b) Coal still dominates the energy mix in 2025. (c) The Indian government plans to launch a new solar mission soon. (d) China leads the world in renewable installations.

Solving it. - Paragraph TONE: positive accomplishments. - A good conclusion either: (i) reinforces the positive trend with a forward-looking note OR (ii) introduces the next-step challenge. - (a) "Yet challenges remain" = balanced acknowledgement of remaining issues. Connects to the success story by saying "more to do" ✓. - (b) Random fact about coal — doesn't conclude the renewable story. - (c) Vague future plan; doesn't tie back to the achievements. - (d) China comparison — irrelevant to India's progress narrative. - **Answer: (a).**

12.6 — CONNECTOR USAGE (SSC CHSL + Banks)

Notation expansion: Pick the BEST linking word (connector / conjunction) to join two ideas. Common connectors: however, moreover, therefore, nevertheless, consequently, in contrast, similarly, on the other hand, in addition.

Q62 (Advanced). "She studied diligently for months. ____ , she failed the entrance exam due to anxiety on the day."

(a) Therefore (b) Moreover (c) Nevertheless (d) In addition

Solving it. - Idea 1: studied diligently → expected outcome = passed. - Idea 2: failed (anxiety) → contradicts the expectation. - Need a CONTRAST connector. - (a) Therefore = consequence (wrong). - (b) Moreover = adds another point (wrong). - (c) Nevertheless = "in spite of that" — contrast ✓. - (d) In addition = adds (wrong). - **Answer: (c) Nevertheless.**

Connector cheat-sheet.

Function	Connector
Contrast	however, nevertheless, on the contrary, in contrast, despite, although
Addition	moreover, furthermore, in addition, also, additionally
Cause	because, since, as
Effect	therefore, consequently, hence, thus
Example	for example, for instance, such as
Sequence	first, then, finally, subsequently
Conclusion	in conclusion, to summarise, all in all

12.7 — PHRASE REPLACEMENT — CONTEXT-BASED (SBI PO Mains)

Different from basic Sentence Improvement (Q11-15) — uses idiomatic phrases or complex grammar.

Q63 (Advanced). "The judge ruled that the contract was **null and void in nature**, citing procedural lapses."

Replace the bold phrase with the best option:

(a) null and void (b) of null and void nature (c) null in nature (d) void in nature

Solving it. - "Null and void" is already a fixed legal idiom meaning invalid; "in nature" is redundant. - (a) **null and void** — concise and standard ✓. - (b), (c), (d) all retain redundancy or weaken the legal idiom. - **Answer: (a) null and void.**

12.8 — SPELLING-IN-PASSAGE (SSC + RBI Asst)

Identify which underlined word in a sentence is misspelt.

Q64 (Advanced). Identify the incorrectly spelt word:

"The (1) **acommodation** at the hotel was (2) **convenient**, with (3) **embarrassing** levels of (4) **luxury**."

Solving it. - (1) "acommodation" — wrong; should be **accommodation** (double c, double m).
- (2) convenient ✓ - (3) embarrassing ✓ (double r, double s) - (4) luxury ✓ - **Answer: (1) accommodation** (correct = accommodation).

Memory peg. Top misspellings in exams: accommodation, occurrence, embarrass, conscience, privilege, separate, convenience.

12.9 — MATCH THE COLUMN (RBI Grade B)

Q65 (Advanced). Match each idiom (Column A) with its meaning (Column B):

Column A	Column B
1. Achilles' heel	(a) Reveal a secret
2. Bell the cat	(b) A weak spot
3. Spill the beans	(c) Take a risky first step
4. Bite the bullet	(d) Endure pain courageously

Solving it. - 1 → b (weak spot) - 2 → c (risky first step) - 3 → a (reveal a secret) - 4 → d (endure pain)

Answer mapping: 1-b, 2-c, 3-a, 4-d.

Section 13 — RESTRUCTURED CORE GRAMMAR (clean bullets, no clubbing)

The following sub-sections take the originally compact grammar rules from earlier in this book and re-present them as clean single-line entries with examples — the format you said earlier was missing.

13.1 — VOICE (Active ↔ Passive) — Quick conversion table

Active form	Passive form	Example
Simple Present (writes)	is/are + V3 (is written)	She writes a letter. → A letter is written by her.
Present Continuous (is writing)	is/are being + V3	She is writing a letter. → A letter is being written by her.
Present Perfect (has written)	has/have been + V3	She has written a letter. → A letter has been written by her.
Simple Past (wrote)	was/were + V3	She wrote a letter. → A letter was written by her.
Past Continuous (was writing)	was/were being + V3	She was writing a letter. → A letter was being written by her.
Past Perfect (had written)	had been + V3	She had written a letter. → A letter had been written by her.
Simple Future (will write)	will be + V3	She will write a letter. → A letter will be written by her.
Future Perfect (will have written)	will have been + V3	She will have written a letter. → A letter will have been written by her.
Modal (can/may/must + V1)	modal + be + V3	She can write the letter. → The letter can be written by her.

Special cases (each on its own line):

- **Imperative — command.** "Open the door." → **Let the door be opened.**
- **Imperative — request.** "Please help me." → **You are requested to help me.**
- **Yes/No question (present).** "Does she write?" → **Is a letter written by her?**
- **Wh-question (who).** "Who broke the cup?" → **By whom was the cup broken?**
- **Wh-question (what).** "What did she say?" → **What was said by her?**
- **Sentence with no object (intransitive).** Cannot be made passive. *He runs* — no passive form.
- **Sentence with two objects.** Either object can become the passive subject.

- Active: *She gave him a gift.*
- Passive 1: *He was given a gift by her.* (indirect object as subject)
- Passive 2: *A gift was given to him by her.* (direct object as subject)

13.2 — DIRECT ↔ INDIRECT SPEECH (Narration) — Single-line rules

Reporting verb past → back-shift tenses in reported clause:

Direct (inside quotes)	Indirect (after that-clause)
Simple Present (write)	Simple Past (wrote)
Present Continuous (am writing)	Past Continuous (was writing)
Present Perfect (have written)	Past Perfect (had written)
Simple Past (wrote)	Past Perfect (had written)
Past Continuous (was writing)	Past Perfect Continuous (had been writing)
Will + V1	Would + V1
Can	Could
May	Might
Must (obligation)	Had to
Shall	Should

Time / place expressions (each on its own line):

- **today** → that day
- **tonight** → that night
- **tomorrow** → the next day / the following day
- **yesterday** → the previous day / the day before
- **last night** → the previous night
- **next week** → the following week
- **here** → there
- **this** → that
- **these** → those
- **now** → then

Sentence types — distinct conversion:

- **Statement.** *He said, "I am happy."* → *He said that he was happy.*
- **Yes/No question.** *He said, "Are you ready?"* → *He asked if/whether I was ready.*
- **Wh-question.** *He said, "Where do you live?"* → *He asked where I lived.*
- **Imperative (order).** *He said, "Close the door."* → *He ordered me to close the door.*

- **Imperative (request).** *He said, "Please help me." → He requested me to help him.*
 - **Imperative (advice).** *He said, "Don't smoke." → He advised me not to smoke.*
 - **Exclamation.** *He said, "What a beautiful day!" → He exclaimed that it was a very beautiful day.*
-

13.3 — CONJUNCTIONS — Single-line categorisation

Coordinating (FANBOYS):

- **For** — because (formal). *She was tired, for she had walked all day.*
- **And** — addition. *He plays cricket and football.*
- **Nor** — neither + alternative. *She doesn't drink, nor does she smoke.*
- **But** — contrast. *He is rich but unhappy.*
- **Or** — choice. *Coffee or tea?*
- **Yet** — surprise contrast. *She is small yet very strong.*
- **So** — result. *It was raining, so we cancelled the picnic.*

Subordinating (introduce dependent clauses):

- **Time:** when, while, before, after, until, since, as soon as.
- **Cause / reason:** because, since, as.
- **Condition:** if, unless, provided that.
- **Concession:** although, though, even though.
- **Purpose:** so that, in order that.
- **Comparison:** as, than.

Correlative pairs (always used together):

- **Either ... or ...** (one of two): *Either you come now, or I will leave.*
- **Neither ... nor ...** (negation of both): *Neither he nor she is coming.*
- **Not only ... but also ...** (addition): *He is not only intelligent but also hardworking.*
- **Both ... and ...** (two together): *Both Ram and Shyam passed.*
- **Whether ... or ...** (dual choice): *I don't know whether he agrees or not.*
- **Hardly ... when ... / No sooner ... than ...** (immediate sequence): *No sooner had I arrived than the rain started.*
- **As ... as ... / so ... as ...** (comparison).

Parallelism rule for correlatives: the two halves must be in the SAME grammatical form (both nouns, both verbs, both phrases).

- ✓ *He is not only intelligent but also hardworking.* (both adjectives)
 - ✗ *He not only plays cricket but also a teacher.* (verb vs noun — wrong)
-

13.4 — PREPOSITIONS — Top-50 fixed pairs (single-line)

Verb + preposition:

- **Account for** = explain.
- **Apply for** (a job) / **apply to** (a person/institution).
- **Believe in** (existence) / **believe of** (an opinion).
- **Comply with** (a rule) — never "comply to".
- **Concentrate on** = focus.
- **Consist of** = be made up of (NEVER "consist in" for ingredients).
- **Decide on** (a course of action).
- **Depend on** = rely on.
- **Differ from** (something) / **differ with** (a person).
- **Disapprove of** = criticise.
- **Insist on** = demand firmly.
- **Object to** = oppose.
- **Prefer X to Y** — never "prefer X than Y".
- **Refer to** = look up; mention.
- **Rely on** / **Relish (no preposition)** — *He relishes spicy food.*
- **Suspect of** (a crime); **suspect that** (a clause).
- **Wait for** (a person/thing) / **wait on** (serve someone).

Adjective + preposition:

- **Afraid of** (fear).
- **Angry with** (a person) / **angry at** (a thing).
- **Capable of**.
- **Confident of** (success).
- **Famous for** (a quality / achievement).
- **Fond of** (liking).
- **Good at** (skill) / **good for** (beneficial).
- **Married to** — never "married with".
- **Proud of**.
- **Responsible for**.
- **Senior / Junior to** — never "than".
- **Similar to**.
- **Used to** + V-ing (accustomed to) vs **used to** + V (past habit).

Noun + preposition:

- **Belief in**.
- **Confidence in**.
- **Cure for** (a disease).
- **Demand for**.
- **Need for**.
- **Reason for**.

- **Solution to** (a problem).
-

13.5 — ARTICLES (a / an / the) — Single-line rules

Use "a" before consonant SOUNDS (not letters):

- *a book, a car, a university* (university starts with /j/ sound = consonant).
- *a one-eyed man* (one starts with /w/ sound).

Use "an" before vowel SOUNDS:

- *an apple, an orange, an honest man* (honest starts with silent h → vowel sound).
- *an MBA* (M starts with /em/ — vowel sound).
- *an X-ray* (X starts with /ek/ — vowel sound).

Use "the" with:

- **Specific things already mentioned or unique.** *The sun, the moon, the Earth.*
- **Superlatives.** *The best player.*
- **Ordinals.** *The first attempt.*
- **Rivers, seas, oceans, mountain RANGES.** *The Ganges, the Pacific, the Himalayas.*
- **Single mountain peaks — NO article.** *Mt. Everest, Mt. K2.*
- **Newspapers, ships.** *The Times of India, the Titanic.*
- **Adjectives used as plural nouns.** *The poor, the rich, the elderly.*
- **Country names (most have NO article).** *India, USA → The United States* (because plural of states).
- **Musical instruments (when speaking generally).** *She plays the piano.*

No article (zero article):

- **Proper nouns.** *Ram, Delhi, India.*
 - **Abstract nouns / general meanings.** *Honesty is the best policy.* (no "the" before honesty)
 - **Plural countable nouns in general meaning.** *Books are knowledge.* (no article)
 - **Uncountable / mass nouns in general meaning.** *Gold is precious.*
 - **Languages.** *He speaks English / Hindi / French.*
 - **Sports played generally.** *He plays cricket / football.*
 - **Most countries.** *India, France, Japan.*
-

PART E — TIMED MINI-MOCK (25 Q · 25 min)

1. Synonym of **CANDID**: (a) honest (b) hidden (c) careful (d) subtle
2. Antonym of **OBSELETE**: (a) modern (b) outdated (c) rare (d) ancient
3. "He is one of the boys who __ honest." (a) is (b) are (c) was (d) has
4. "Neither he nor I __ correct." (a) am (b) is (c) are (d) be
5. "The committee __ decided." (a) has (b) have (c) is (d) am
6. Idiom "**to add fuel to the fire**": (a) cool down (b) make worse (c) extinguish (d) ignore
7. OWS for "place where coins are minted": (a) treasury (b) mint (c) bank (d) reserve
8. Cloze: "She __ the report yesterday." (a) submit (b) submitted (c) submits (d) submitting
9. Sentence improvement: "I have went there." → corrected? (a) have gone (b) had went (c) has gone (d) had gone
10. Preposition: "He is fond __ chocolates." (a) of (b) for (c) on (d) at
11. Synonym **TENACIOUS**: (a) weak (b) persistent (c) angry (d) loud
12. Antonym **TURBULENT**: (a) chaotic (b) calm (c) windy (d) angry
13. Article: "She is __ honest girl." (a) a (b) an (c) the (d) no article
14. Plural of "**deer**": (a) deers (b) deer (c) deeren (d) dee
15. Direct/Indirect: He said, "I am happy." → He said that __.
16. Idiom "**once in a blue moon**": (a) often (b) very rarely (c) night-time (d) sky-coloured
17. Foreign phrase "**bona fide**": (a) fake (b) genuine (c) hidden (d) sudden
18. Spelling correct: (a) accomodate (b) accommodate (c) acomodate (d) accommadate
19. "She prefers tea __ coffee." (a) than (b) over (c) to (d) instead
20. Verb tense: "By next year, I __ here for 5 years." (a) will live (b) will have lived (c) lived (d) am living
21. OWS "fear of crowds": (a) acrophobia (b) agoraphobia (c) hydrophobia (d) xenophobia
22. Antonym **VERBOSE**: (a) wordy (b) brief (c) flowery (d) silent
23. Synonym **PRUDENT**: (a) reckless (b) wasteful (c) cautious (d) hasty
24. Idiom "**to spill the beans**": (a) eat carelessly (b) reveal a secret (c) waste food (d) cause mess
25. "He is junior __ me." (a) than (b) to (c) over (d) by

Answer key: 1-a, 2-a, 3-b, 4-a, 5-a, 6-b, 7-b, 8-b, 9-a, 10-a, 11-b, 12-b, 13-b, 14-b, 15-(he was happy), 16-b, 17-b, 18-b, 19-c, 20-b, 21-b, 22-b, 23-c, 24-b, 25-b.

PART F — TRAP-RECOGNITION CARDS (English)

Trap	Where	How to spot
"Each / every / either / neither / none" → singular verb	S-V agreement	Always singular
"One of the X who/that" → verb agrees with X (plural)	S-V agreement	Verb plural after "one of the"
"Either A or B" → verb agrees with B (closer)	Conjunction	Closest noun rule
"Prefer X than Y" — wrong	Prepositions	Always "to"
"Discuss about", "Cope up with", "Return back"	Redundancy	Drop the prep / "back"
"Less" vs "fewer"	Articles/quantifiers	Less for uncountable, fewer for countable
"Since" vs "for"	Tenses	Since + point; for + duration
Comparatives "more better/most strongest"	Sentence improvement	Never double
"Junior than" — wrong	Prepositions	Always "junior to"
"If I was" — wrong (subjunctive)	Tense	"If I were" for unreal condition

Drill all 50 + mini-mock twice. Combine with vocab tables (Part 16) for >90% English mastery.